

Module 01: Systems — The Rules of the Game

Learning Objectives

1. Understand that a **Game** is a System made of Rules.
2. Learn that **Boundaries** (The lines on the field) tell us where to play.
3. Know that without Rules, there is no Game!

Introduction: Chaos vs. Order

Imagine a soccer game with NO rules.

- Someone picks up the ball.
- Someone runs out of the stadium.
- Someone eats the goal net. Is that fun? No! It is confusing. Rules (Constraints) make the fun possible. They tell us what we can and cannot do.

Key Concepts

1. The Boundary (The Magic Circle)

Every game has a space.

- The Chessboard.
- The Soccer Field.
- The Pillow Fort. Inside the circle, the rules apply. Outside, they don't. (You can't tackle your sister in the kitchen!).

2. The Constraints (The Rules)

Rules limit your action.

- "Don't touch the floor." (Floor is Lava).

- "Don't say the secret word." (Taboo). Limiting what you can do forces you to be CREATIVE.

3. Fairness (The Algorithm)

For a game to work, everyone must run the same code. If Player A follows rules and Player B cheats, the System breaks. Fairness = Shared Rules.

Activities

Activity 1: The New Rule

Play a simple game (Tag). Add ONE new rule.

- "You can only hop."
- "You are safe if you touch a tree." Does it make the game harder? More fun? You are designing a System!

Activity 2: Boundary Detectives

Go to a playground or park. Find the boundaries.

- Where does the sandbox end?
- Where does the slide start? Draw a map of the "Game Zones."

Summary

Systems need rules to work. By respecting the rules and boundaries, we create a space where everyone can play together and have fun.

References

- *Rules of Play* by Katie Salen (Parent Reading)
- *Lilly's Purple Plastic Purse* by Kevin Henkes